

FUEL GREATNESS

VOLUME 01 · 2026 EDITION FOR
PARENTS & YOUNG ATHLETES

NUTRITION GUIDE.

Your go-to resource for delicious, balanced meals designed to energize, recover, and grow with your young athlete, making every bite a step toward their success.

BY

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A NOTE FROM GABBY

LET'S FUEL GREATNESS, ONE BITE AT A TIME.

As a former Division I athlete and now a mom to two 14-year-old volleyball players, I know firsthand how essential proper nutrition is to athletic performance, and how hard it can be to get kids to eat, let alone eat healthy, nutrient-rich meals.

This guide is a carefully crafted roadmap to help you fuel your young athlete's body with meals they'll actually enjoy, while ensuring they get the energy and nutrients they need to excel both on and off the court.

GABBY

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Four chapters to help you plan, prep, and perform with confidence.

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THE BASICS OF SPORTS NUTRITION.

Fueling young athletes is about more than satisfying hunger. It's about giving them the right fuel to perform, recover, and grow. We'll cover the why, the macros, and the hydration that ties it all together.

01

WHY NUTRITION MATTERS

02

MACRONUTRIENTS

03

THE POWER OF HYDRATION

WHY NUTRITION IS THE SECRET WEAPON.

THINK OF YOUR CHILD'S
BODY AS A FINELY
TUNED **ENGINE**. THE
BETTER THE FUEL, THE
BETTER IT RUNS.

Nutrition directly impacts an athlete's energy levels, stamina, strength, focus, and recovery. Proper fueling can mean the difference between finishing a tournament strong or hitting a wall mid-game.

01

ENERGY & ENDURANCE

Carbohydrates supply both quick and sustained energy through long matches.

02

MUSCLE REPAIR

Protein repairs and rebuilds muscle tissue post-workout for steady growth.

03

FASTER RECOVERY

Proper post-game nutrition reduces soreness and accelerates recovery.

04

MENTAL FOCUS

A well-fed brain stays sharp and focused, especially during long matches.

UNDERSTANDING MACRONUTRIENTS.

Carbs, proteins, and fats each play a distinct role in fueling, repairing, and sustaining a young athlete’s body. Here’s how to think about each one.

01

CARBOHYDRATES

THE PRIMARY FUEL

Carbs break down into glucose, which fuels muscles during exercise. Pre-game meals should be carb-heavy.

SOURCES

Oatmeal, fruits, whole-grain bread, sweet potatoes, rice, granola bars, smoothies.

QUICK TIP

Choose complex carbs like whole grains over refined carbs for sustained energy.

NUTRITION GUIDE

02

PROTEINS

THE BUILDING BLOCKS

Protein repairs muscle fibers after exercise and supports growth. Post-workout recovery is critical.

SOURCES

Chicken, turkey, fish, eggs, Greek yogurt, protein shakes, beans, and nuts.

QUICK TIP

Aim for 20–30 grams of protein post-workout to maximize recovery.

03

FATS

LONG-LASTING ENERGY

Fats provide long-term energy and help absorb vitamins. Avoid heavy fats right before workouts.

SOURCES

Avocados, olive oil, nuts, seeds, and fatty fish like salmon.

QUICK TIP

Pair fats with lean proteins and complex carbs for balanced meals.

THE POWER OF HYDRATION.

Hydration improves muscle function, regulates body temperature, and boosts mental clarity. Dehydrated athletes are more prone to fatigue, cramps, and reduced focus.

16–20

oz

BEFORE ACTIVITY

Drink 16–20 oz. of water 2–3 hours before exercise.

+ELEC.

SESSIONS > 60
MIN

DURING ACTIVITY

Add an electrolyte drink for any session longer than 60 minutes.

16–20

oz

AFTER ACTIVITY

Rehydrate with 16–20 oz. of water within 30 minutes to an hour after finishing.

SIGNS OF DEHYDRATION

- Fatigue or sluggishness
- Headaches or dizziness
- Dry mouth
- Decreased performance

ELECTROLYTE SOURCES

- Low-sugar sports drinks
- Coconut water
- Oranges and watermelon

PRE-WORKOUT FUEL.

A well-fueled athlete is a prepared athlete. What your child eats before a workout or game determines how well they perform, how long they sustain energy, and how quickly they recover.

01

TIMING YOUR MEAL

02

ENERGY-PACKED IDEAS

03

FOODS TO AVOID

TIMING YOUR PRE-WORKOUT MEAL.

Eating 1–3 hours before exercise gives the body time to digest and absorb nutrients for optimal performance.

3 HRS

TOO EARLY

Eating too long before exercise may leave the athlete low on energy at game time.

1–3 HRS

THE SWEET SPOT

This window ensures food is broken down into glucose, ready to fuel muscles.

< 1 HR

TOO CLOSE

Eating less than an hour before can cause cramps, indigestion, and sluggishness.

ENERGY-PACKED MEAL IDEAS.

01

BANANA & NUT BUTTER SANDWICH

Whole-grain bread, a banana, and peanut or almond butter.

Carbs from the bread and banana provide quick energy; nut butter adds protein and healthy fats.

02

GREEK YOGURT WITH BERRIES

Plain Greek yogurt topped with mixed berries and a drizzle of honey.

Protein from the yogurt and simple sugars from the berries help maintain energy without feeling heavy.

03

OATMEAL WITH FRUIT

Rolled oats cooked with milk, topped with diced apple or banana and cinnamon.

Complex carbs from the oats provide sustained energy; fruit adds a natural sugar boost.

04

FRUIT & PROTEIN SMOOTHIE

Frozen berries, banana, Greek yogurt, and a splash of orange juice or water.

Hydrating, energizing, and easy on the stomach. Balance with protein and fiber to avoid sugar spikes.

Smoothies high in sugar but low in fiber, protein, or fat are more likely to cause a blood sugar spike. A balanced mix has a more gradual effect.

FOODS TO AVOID BEFORE EXERCISE.

THE WRONG MEAL CAN COST THE GAME.

Heavy foods are harder to digest and can divert blood flow away from the muscles, making it difficult to perform at peak levels.

QUICK FIX

Test pre-workout meals during practice, not competitions.
What works for one athlete may not work for another.

✗

FRIED & GREASY FOODS

Burgers, fried chicken, fries, and heavy sauces can cause digestive distress.

✗

HIGH-FAT FOODS

Excess fats take longer to digest, slowing down energy availability.

✗

EXCESS FIBER

Important for overall health, but too much before exercise leads to bloating or cramping.

✗

SUGARY SNACKS & SODAS

A quick energy spike often results in an energy crash mid-game.

TOURNAMENT DAY STRATEGY.

Tournament days are a test of physical and mental stamina. Strategic fueling, timing meals correctly, balancing nutrients, and staying consistent, makes a real difference in energy, focus, and recovery.

01

AM WAVE VS. PM WAVE

02

MENTAL & PHYSICAL RECOVERY

AM WAVE VS. PM WAVE.

AM

7–8 AM START

PRE-GAME BREAKFAST · 1–2 HRS BEFORE

Oatmeal topped with fruit and honey
Whole-grain toast with peanut butter and banana
Fruit and yogurt smoothie with chia seeds

MID-MORNING SNACKS · BETWEEN GAMES

Orange slices or watermelon cubes
Low-sugar granola bars
Protein balls made with oats, nut butter, and honey

PM

2–3 PM START

PRE-GAME LUNCH · 11 AM–12 PM

Turkey & cheese sandwich on whole-grain bread with apple slices
Pasta salad with grilled chicken and veggies
Protein pasta with light tomato sauce and lean meatballs

MID-AFTERNOON SNACKS · BETWEEN GAMES

Trail mix with nuts, seeds, and dried fruit
Rice cakes with almond butter
Fruit cups

MENTAL + PHYSICAL RECOVERY.

RECOVERY ISN'T JUST
FOOD. IT'S **REST AND
RESETS.**

Within 30 minutes after the last game, a balanced meal with carbs, protein, and healthy fats is essential. Encourage athletes to take short breaks between games to stretch, rehydrate, and clear their minds.

OPTION 01

GRILLED CHICKEN & QUINOA

PROTEIN

Grilled chicken breast

CARB

Quinoa

VEG

Roasted vegetables

OPTION 02

SALMON & SWEET POTATO

PROTEIN

Baked salmon

CARB

Sweet potatoes

VEG

Sautéed spinach

OPTION 03

TURKEY & AVOCADO WRAP

PROTEIN

Sliced turkey

FAT

Avocado

SIDE

Fresh fruit

HEALTHY EATING ON THE GO.

Traveling for tournaments creates real challenges for nutrition. Strategic planning helps avoid unhealthy options and keeps energy levels consistent, from catering, to restaurants, to the flight itself.

01

CATERING FOR TRAVEL

02

CHOOSING RESTAURANTS

03

TRAVEL HYDRATION

UTILIZING CATERING SERVICES.

Catering allows for tailored, customized meals delivered to your location, reducing the need to find suitable restaurants on tight game-day timelines.

01

WHY CATERING WORKS

BENEFITS

- Customized menus that meet the nutritional needs of young athletes
- Convenient delivery direct to your location
- Family-style portions suitable for full teams

RECOMMENDED OPTIONS

- EZ Cater connects you with local caterers and varied cuisines
- Restaurant catering offers team-style options at many restaurants

02

HOW TO ORDER WELL

BUILD A BALANCED MENU

- Mix proteins, carbohydrates, and vegetables in every order
- Skip heavy fried items and high-sugar sides
- Include fresh fruit and hydrating sides

PLAN THE TIMING

- Schedule deliveries to align with game and practice times
- Allow 60–90 minutes between eating and play

CHOOSING THE RIGHT RESTAURANTS.



LOOK FOR

RECOMMENDED TYPES

- Family-style restaurants offering varied dishes for different needs
- Buffets with a range of healthy choices and balanced options
- Restaurants that publish their menus online for advance review

TIPS FOR CHOOSING

- Review menus in advance to assess healthy options
- Confirm the restaurant can accommodate dietary restrictions



AVOID

SKIP THESE

- Fast-food chains, typically high in unhealthy fats, sugar, and sodium
- Establishments with limited healthy options or only fried items
- Places primarily serving processed or pre-frozen menus

WHY IT MATTERS

- These foods hinder athletic performance and slow recovery
- High sodium can affect hydration on travel days

HYDRATION DURING TRAVEL.

Airplane cabins typically have low humidity (10–20%), which leads to fluid loss. Dehydration impairs performance, increases fatigue, and elevates altitude sickness risk.

01

PRE-HYDRATE BEFORE BOARDING

WHY

Cabin humidity around 10–20% leads to increased fluid loss in flight.

STRATEGY

Drink water consistently in the days leading up to the flight; 16–20 oz before boarding.

02

MAINTAIN FLUIDS IN-FLIGHT

WHY

The dry cabin causes moisture loss through skin and respiratory system.

STRATEGY

Aim for 8 oz of water every hour. Set reminders to take regular sips, especially on long flights.

03

MONITOR ELECTROLYTE LEVELS

WHY

Electrolytes are essential for muscle function and fluid balance.

STRATEGY

Incorporate electrolyte-rich beverages or supplements, especially during physical activity.

CLOSING

THANK
YOU.

Just like the skill and development side of volleyball, nutrition is a journey filled with trial, discovery, and progress. The concepts in this guide are tools to get you started: flexible, adaptable, and personalized to meet the evolving needs of your young athlete.

Take these ideas, play with them, and make them your own. Try new meal combinations, test different pre-game snacks, and explore travel-friendly options that fit your family's routine.

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ONE BITE AT A TIME.**